members to earn points when they fly. A traditional requirements specification document might include something like this:

```
Members will earn Frequent Flyer points from Flying High flights and from
    partner flights.
```

This may capture the essence of what you need to build, but it's a little vague. How many points should a member earn per flight? Will members earn the same number of points on Flying High flights as on partner flights? Do the flights on partner companies have to be booked through Flying High, or is any flight on a partner airline applicable? Will members earn more points if they fly in Premium Economy or Business? And so on.

If you leave these questions unaddressed now, the development team will have to make decisions and judgment calls about the most appropriate solutions. They may have to ask additional questions during development, which will slow down the project as they wait for answers. Or they may incorrectly assume that they've understood what's needed, and implement a solution that doesn't correspond to what the business really needs. In both cases, time and effort is wasted.

As we saw in the previous chapter, discussing concrete examples with the users and stakeholders is a great way to flush out and eliminate this sort of ambiguity, making sure everyone is on the same page. You use the language and vocabulary of your stakeholders to clarify aspects that you're not clear about, and you'll often discover things that the stakeholders hadn't originally thought about, had assumed you knew, or had forgotten to mention. For example, Sarah, a business analyst, and Paul from the Flying High marketing team might have a conversation like this one to drill deeper into how Frequent Flyer points are earned:

> Sarah: Can you give me an example? How many Frequent Flyer points would I earn if I flew from Sydney to Melbourne in Economy?
>
> Paul: Well, the distance from Sydney to Melbourne is 878 km, and base points are calculated at half a point per kilometer, so if you fly with Flying High from Sydney to Melbourne in Economy, you'd earn 439 points.
>
> Sarah: OK. Is there a way I might earn more or less points flying this trip?
>
> Paul: Well, if you were a Silver Frequent Flyer, you'd get a 50% Status Bonus as well, so you'd earn 659 points.
>
> Sarah: And what if I was a Gold Frequent Flyer?
>
> Paul: In that case, you'd earn a 75% Status Bonus, but you'd also be entitled to the Guaranteed Minimum Point Earnings, which for Economy is 1000 points, so you'd earn 1000 points.

As with many real-world requirements, and as you can also see in figure 5.2, things get more complicated when you start to look into the details. We'll come back to this example several times during this chapter. But already in this conversation you've learned about three business rules: